

Universe at War: Earth Assault

For thousands of years, mankind has stared at the stars with awe and wonder. After today, we'll wish we were blind

Oh God no!—Not another alien invasion...please. These were initial thoughts. Thankfully, *UAW: EA* does things a little differently. At the beginning, I'd go "jeez, couldn't they make this game better looking?" but then you find that the graphics aren't as archaic as they seem, with some nice transparency effects and more. The cut scenes definitely need some make up work—they're bland, along the same lines as the cut scenes in *Warcraft 3*, a six year old game! *UAW: EA* has a couple of tricks up its sleeve, which become apparent once you spend some time with the game. For one—it plays a slightly different storyline (no spoilers!) but you will be entertained. The second trick won't be apparent till you play through a good bit of the game—Unlike most RTS' which have different units with similar properties, you'll find a completely different menu system for each faction—unique research trees and even more unique units—types of weapons, even modes of travel and each unit gets a unique ability...yay!

The Story: The Novus play the crusaders, come to rescue the sentinents (humans) from a hostile alien invasion force (the Hierarchy). The humans fade into the background, as the fighting between these two factions awakes a third and ultimately more dangerous force lying dormant somewhere inside the planet—the Masari. With such an intergalactic storyline, it's nice to see mankind take a backseat for once.

The Novus is a faction of cybernetic beings that are basically hit and run experts characterised by fast movement speeds, fast attacks, and low health. They befriend you in the beginning of the single player campaign, where you play as earth forces, and soon you'll be controlling the Novus. The Novus basically thrives on mobility and they have an energy network through which collector drones travel (at speeds of light) and forage for resources. You can even instantly transport armies from power node to power node.

The faction Hierarchy are the bad guys, and all their powers centre around walkers. They have the Habitat walker—a lumbering colossus, armed with a number of powerful weapons in addition to the ability to spawn troops from pods. He has a number of nodes that can be upgraded to create units, or wield deadlier weapons. While the Novus survive with hit-and-run tactics, the Hierarchy follows a brute force approach.

The Masari are the last race in the game and they don't have the guerrilla tactics of the Novus, nor the numbers of the Hierarchy. Instead, they have fewer, costlier and more powerful units. The Masari also have a twist in their resource gathering and don't salvage like the other two races. Instead, they build batteries that charge up slowly, and gradually add



UNIVERSE AT WAR
EARTH ASSAULT™
Rating: 8.5/10
Developer: Petroglyph
Publisher: Sega

digit GAMING PC
XFX GeForce 8800 Ultra,
Intel Core 2 Duo E6600,
4 GB DDR2 RAM,
Windows Vista Ultimate x64

to your resources. They also have the option of going light or dark with the energy produced, which alters the abilities of some buildings and units.

All three factions have hero units, and in the campaign, if your hero dies—it's game over. Thankfully, most heroes are capable of taking care of themselves, unless swarmed by enemies en masse. In the campaign, you'll eventually play as all three civilisations, one at a time, through three distinct campaigns.

A very good game, definitely a must try for RTS fans, with a decent plot and entertaining units. The big let down for me was the inability to zoom out of battles, and the camera control could have been much better—a blemish on an otherwise spotless canvas. A refreshing change from most RTS'—this, and one which should keep you engaged with a robust online multiplayer component as well.

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